ANVAIR Case Study

Minimal Apple Watch timer for strength training

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Product concept, interaction design, development

Product Snapshot

ANVAIR is a minimal Apple Watch training timer designed to keep strength athletes on schedule between sets without interrupting the flow of training.

Platform: Apple Watch
Role: Product concept, interaction design, development
Status: Launching on the Apple App Store (Beta)

The product focuses on a single job. Managing rest time between strength training sets without pulling the athlete out of the workout.

Ready

Rest Running

Completion Signal

Product Narrative

Strength training follows a simple rhythm. Effort, recovery, effort again.

Between sets, attention is scattered. Athletes catch their breath, watch the gym around them, or check their phones. Rest timing is easy to lose track of, and missing the right window can disrupt the intensity and flow of a workout.

Most tools that attempt to solve this problem live inside complex fitness tracking apps. They require constant attention or interaction, which pulls the athlete out of the moment.

ANVAIR was designed as a focused tool that quietly manages rest timing so athletes can stay mentally present in their workout. Rather than adding another complicated training system, the product reduces the problem to its simplest form. A timer that communicates clearly and stays out of the way.

Problem

Rest timing is critical for maintaining consistent training intensity, but most solutions introduce friction.

Common issues include:

Timers buried inside complex workout trackers
Interfaces that require visual attention
Interactions that interrupt the rhythm of training

The result is a tool that competes with the workout instead of supporting it.

Insight

- Between sets, attention is fragmented.
- Athletes are rarely staring at their watch. They are breathing, scanning the room, or mentally preparing for the next effort.
- The timer must work without requiring visual focus.
- This insight drove the design of ANVAIR.

Product Principles

One job done well

ANVAIR exists for a single purpose. Getting the athlete to their next set on time.

Eyes free interaction

The timer communicates through clear haptic signals, so the user does not need to watch the screen.

Zero cognitive overhead

The interface must be predictable and immediate. Interaction should take seconds, not attention.

Respect the rhythm of training

The product should support the cadence of strength training, not interrupt it.

Solution

ANVAIR is a minimal watchOS timer built around a small set of interaction states.

The athlete sets a rest duration using the Digital Crown and starts the timer with a tap. The watch then handles the rest cycle automatically.

Subtle haptic signals prepare the user for the next set, culminating in a clear completion alert.

The product then immediately returns to the ready state so the next set can begin without additional setup.

Testing and Iteration

Because ANVAIR is designed for use during active training sessions, the product was tested directly in real workouts rather than simulated environments.

Early versions of the timer were used during strength training sessions to observe how the interaction model held up when attention was limited and physical movement was involved.

These tests revealed several important behaviors:

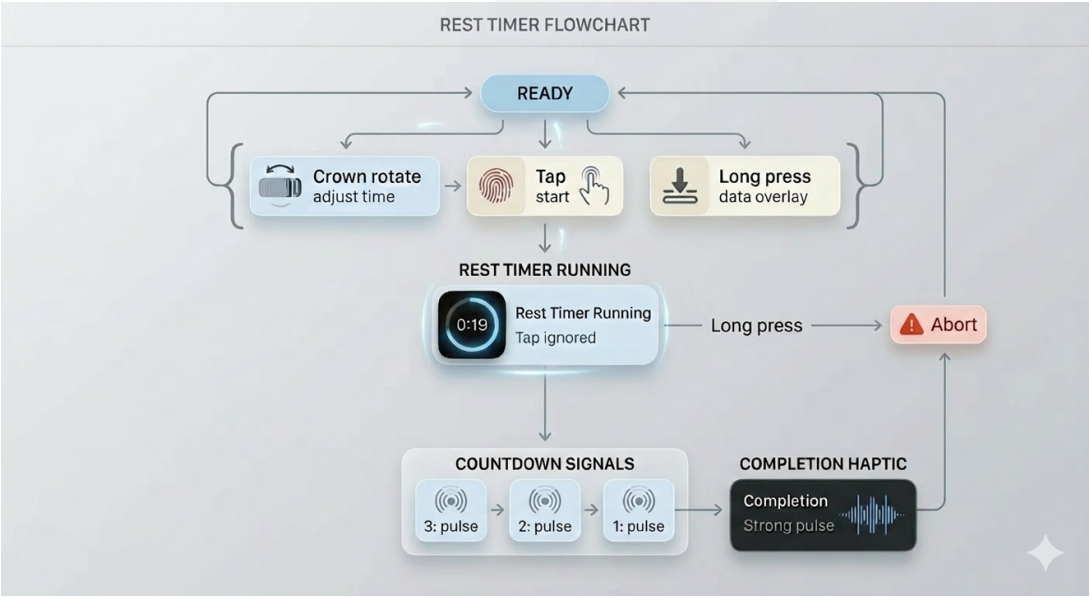
- Accidental taps occur frequently during workouts
- Users rarely look directly at the watch during rest periods

- Clear haptic signals are more effective than visual countdowns

These observations reinforced several key design decisions. Interaction during the rest state was intentionally restricted, and the countdown sequence was designed around tactile signals rather than visual or audio cues.

Interaction System

The product is structured around a small number of states.



The system intentionally separates configuration from execution. All optional interactions occur in the Ready state,

while the rest timer limits interaction to prevent accidental input during physical activity.

Key Design Decisions

Minimal interface states

Reducing the number of states lowers cognitive load during workouts.

Strong haptic communication

The watch should communicate timing through touch, not constant visual checking.

Immediate reset behavior

The timer returns to ready automatically, so the next set begins without friction.

Restricted interaction during rest

Tap gestures are ignored during the rest cycle to prevent accidental cancellation. Aborting the timer requires a deliberate long press.

ANVAIR intentionally limits the number of interaction states, so the timer remains predictable during workouts when user attention is limited.

What I Intentionally Did Not Build

Many training apps include extensive tracking and analytics features.

ANVAIR intentionally avoids:

Workout logging
Set tracking
Performance analytics

These features dilute the core job of the product. The goal was to create a tool that quietly supports training rather than becoming another system the athlete must manage.

Future Direction

The focused timer creates the foundation for additional tools under the ANVAIR brand.

Possible extensions include heart rate driven rest timing and interval pacing tools. Each product would follow the same design philosophy of solving a single job with minimal interaction.

Product Development

ANVAIR was designed and built as a solo project. The process included:

- Interaction design and prototyping
- watchOS implementation
- haptic pattern design
- real world testing during training sessions

What I Learned Building ANVAIR

Designing a simple product is often harder than building a complex one.

Every additional feature introduces cognitive overhead. The process reinforced the value of designing around a clear job and resisting the temptation to expand scope.

The most important decisions in this product were not about adding functionality but about removing friction.

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